11-20 第2篇

阅读理解（说明文） Why Is Yawning Contagious?

① It is the eighth lesson on a Wednesday afternoon. The teacher, halfway through a chemistry slide, suddenly opens her mouth in a long, tired **yawn**. She turns away politely. Within two seconds, the boy in the front row yawns too. Within ten seconds, three students near the window are yawning. By the time the slide changes, **half the class has yawned at least once**. We laugh, a little embarrassed; the teacher laughs too. We have all just taken part in one of the strangest and most common little dances of the human body — **a yawn that travels from one person to another**. Why does this happen? After many years of study, scientists have found a beautiful answer.

② First, what is a yawn at all? A yawn is a long, **deep breath in**, with the mouth wide open, followed by a short breath out. It happens about **5 to 10 times a day** in most healthy people, more often when they are tired, hungry, slightly cold, or trying to wake up. The first job of a yawn is to **stretch the small muscles around the throat and the jaw**, and to bring in a large breath of fresh air. Some scientists also believe a yawn helps **cool the brain** by a tiny fraction of a degree. None of this, however, explains why your yawn so easily catches my own.

③ The first part of the explanation is **the brain's mirror system**. Inside our brains, there are special cells called **mirror neurons**. When you watch someone do an action — lift a cup, smile, scratch a knee — these neurons quietly **fire as if you were doing it yourself**. They were first noticed in monkeys in the 1990s, when researchers saw that the brain area for "lifting a peanut" lit up just from watching another monkey lift one. In humans, the mirror system is even more developed: it helps us understand other people, copy their habits, and learn their emotions. Yawning is one of the small actions our mirror system loves the most.

④ But the mirror system alone is not enough. Studies show that **dogs catch yawns from their owners**, but not from strangers. Children below the age of about **4 or 5** rarely catch yawns. Children with certain conditions that make it hard to read other people's feelings often do not catch them either. From these patterns, scientists have drawn a beautiful conclusion: **catching a yawn is closely linked to empathy** — the brain's ability to feel a small bit of what another person feels. The closer your relationship with someone, the more easily their yawn becomes yours.

⑤ This is supported by an experiment from the University of Pisa in 2011. Researchers watched 109 adults in everyday life — at home, at work, on holidays. They counted who caught a yawn from whom, and how quickly. The result was clear: yawns were **most**

easily caught between family members and close friends, less easily caught between casual workmates, and **least easily caught between strangers**. The yawn that travels in a quiet classroom on a Wednesday afternoon, then, is not a sign of bad manners — it is a small, silent **signal of social closeness**.

⑥ Why does the body do this? One leading idea is **group safety**. Our far ancestors lived in small bands; if one person yawned because the night was coming and her brain wanted a fresh, cool burst of oxygen, it was useful for the rest of the band to also take a deep breath at almost the same time. The whole group could then **stay alert together** — or, if they were preparing for sleep, **prepare to rest together**. The catching yawn is a tiny, quiet **synchroniser**, a way for a small group to keep its rhythm without needing words.

⑦ A few more interesting findings make the picture fuller. First, **just reading or thinking about yawning** can make you yawn — many readers will yawn at some point during this passage, even alone in their room. (You may have done so already.) Second, **yawning is more catching after lunch**, when the brain is naturally a little tireder. Third, the **right side of the brain** seems to be more responsible for catching yawns; people with damage to certain right-side areas are less likely to "mirror" them. The yawn, in other words, is a small but careful piece of biology, not an accident.

⑧ So the next time the boy at the front yawns and three students by the window follow, remember: the yawn is not a sign that your class is boring. It is a sign that the small, quiet **mirror inside each of you is still working** — that your brains are still gently tied to one another. We are, in this small way, more connected than we usually realise. Even a tired, sleepy class on a Wednesday afternoon is, in its own quiet biology, **a single soft team breathing together**. That, in itself, is a small, surprising kind of beauty.

注释： yawn 哈欠；mirror neuron 镜像神经元；empathy 共情；synchronise 使同步；biology 生物学

根据短文内容，选择最佳答案。

1. According to Paragraph ②, which of the following is TRUE about a yawn?

A. A yawn is just a small breath out.
B. A yawn is a long, deep breath in with the mouth wide open, followed by a short breath out; it happens 5—10 times a day in most healthy people; it stretches small muscles around the throat and jaw, brings in fresh air, and some scientists believe it helps cool the brain by a tiny fraction of a degree.
C. A yawn happens only when we are sad.
D. A yawn happens only at night.

2. What are mirror neurons, and why are they important here?

A. Tiny cells that produce light.
B. Special brain cells, first noticed in monkeys in the 1990s, that fire as if you were doing the action yourself when you watch someone else do it; in humans they help us understand others, copy their habits and learn their emotions — yawning is one of the small actions the mirror system "loves" the most.
C. Only Chinese students have them.
D. Cells that store memories of yawns.

3. According to Paragraph ④, what evidence shows that catching a yawn is closely linked to EMPATHY?

A. Dogs catch yawns from any human.
B. All babies catch yawns easily.
C. Dogs catch yawns from their owners but not from strangers; children below about 4—5 rarely catch yawns; children with certain conditions that make it hard to read others' feelings often do not catch them either; therefore catching a yawn is closely linked to empathy — the closer the relationship, the more easily another person's yawn becomes yours.
D. Only adults yawn.

4. What did the 2011 University of Pisa study find?

A. Yawns are equally caught between strangers and family members.
B. Yawns are most easily caught between family members and close friends, less easily between casual workmates, and least easily between strangers.
C. Strangers catch yawns more easily than friends.
D. Yawns are not contagious at all.

5. What is the author's main message in the last paragraph?

A. Class is boring and students should sleep.
B. A yawn travelling around a class is not a sign of boredom; it is a sign that the quiet mirror inside each student is still working — that students' brains are gently tied to one another; even a tired class is a soft team breathing together.
C. Catching yawns is dangerous.
D. Students should never yawn.

答案与解析

1.
【答案】B
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第②段全段
【解析】哈欠定义直引。A、C、D 均错。故选 B。

2.
【答案】B
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第③段镜像神经元解释
【解析】功能与发现历史直引。A、C、D 均错。故选 B。

3.
【答案】C
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第④段三类证据
【解析】共情联系直引。A、B、D 均错。故选 C。

4.
【答案】B
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第⑤段 Pisa 研究结果
【解析】关系–易感度排序直引。A、C、D 均错。故选 B。

5.
【答案】B
【题型】推理判断题
【定位】第⑧段结尾
【解析】"软性团队"主题。A、C、D 均偏离。故选 B。